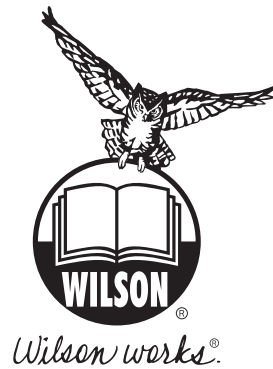


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Old Medicine PART ONE

Modern medicine has a strange past. Today, if you fall and cut your arm, you go to a doctor for help. They examine you, bandage your wound, and give you medicine to prevent infection. However, it was not so long ago when treatments looked quite different. You may not have seen a doctor at all, and the treatment may have been with odd machinery, other illnesses, and even bugs!

Polio is a very serious illness that can lead to paralysis, which means you can't walk. In the early 1900s, before successful preventative medicine was developed, it could be found almost everywhere. When someone got sick with polio, it became difficult to breathe. In 1927 two experts developed a machine called the iron lung. A person's entire body was put

in this huge machine to allow them to breathe. On average, a sick person would spend two weeks inside, but doctors would elongate their stay when needed. The iron lung was creepy looking and difficult to use. Still, it was an effective treatment at the time.

Another favorite common treatment was blood drainage. When someone had a skin condition or infection, they may be offered this treatment. A considerate medic would fixate an insect to the problem area to suck out the blood. It may sound yucky, but today we know for sure that blood drainage can work for some conditions. However, we usually use needles now.

While these treatments may seem strange or difficult, they were (and can still be) safe and effective. Other treatments did not meet these same standards.

Old Medicine PART TWO

It's a fact that medicine was frequently approached in risky ways. Medics often made a problem worse when they used one illness to treat another. Knowing it could kill some germs, a few people were purposely infected with a fever. Medics would also use a treatment for one illness to cure another, even when there was no clear linkage between the two. They would encourage sick people to try these risky, uncertain treatments. As you would expect, the average person did not improve with such poor advice.

Sometimes, a person would end up with a different kind of treatment altogether. There was such a shortage of well-trained medics that many people would go to anyone with access to medicines. These people would impersonate trained medics and give really bad advice.

They would examine a very sick person and pretend they knew why that person was ill. To treat their illness, the ‘medic’ might speak in another language while administering deadly medicine. A large percentage of the public thought this was an effective treatment for many illnesses. The promise of relief from pain was just too hard to resist.

While this kind of care is seen as harmful now, it did help us push forward. Without it we wouldn’t know how important it is to keep a bandage clean or a fever down. Trial and error research helped build the foundation for modern medicine, and for that we should all be thankful. Just fewer insects, please!

Two Heroines in Medicine PART ONE

When you hear the word hero or heroine, you will likely think about someone who has courage, strength, and a commitment to accomplish great things. These words precisely describe two passionate women in American history: Elizabeth Blackwell and Clara Barton.

Both women made significant contributions to the well-being of others. Elizabeth Blackwell was the first woman to complete medical school in the U.S. Clara Barton made her mark, first as a nurse during the Civil War, then as the founder of the American Red Cross.

Blackwell and Barton were both born in the year 1821. Elizabeth was born in February near Bristol, England. Clara was born in December in North Oxford, Massachusetts. Both women had several siblings

growing up and both women affectionately spent time in their early adult life in the teaching profession.

Clara Barton was not your average teen. In fact, she established the first public school in Bordentown, New Jersey, when she was just 17 years old. In 1854, she moved to Washington D.C., and got a job in the U.S. Patent Office. She was one of the first women to work for the federal government. During the Civil War, Clara compassionately worked on the front lines as a nurse to Union soldiers. After the war, Clara made a promise to examine the problem of missing soldiers. She led a nationwide crusade that helped validate the location of 22,000 missing men.

Two Heroines in Medicine PART TWO

After finishing her work with the soldiers, Clara Barton traveled to Europe. There, she visited the Red Cross in Switzerland. This organization was established to protect the sick and wounded during wartime. The visit gave Clara the encouragement to help start the American Red Cross. She was the organization's president until she finally quit working at the age of 83. Clara Barton passed away in 1912.

A sick friend can be credited for Elizabeth Blackwell's decision to study medicine. Elizabeth was not the average medical student as she had to face much discrimination from others who didn't think women should become doctors. However, she did not let this injustice or their inconsiderate actions affect her. In fact, she finished at the top of her class in 1849. Elizabeth went on to London and Paris to advance her training.

When she returned to New York City, she opened a small hospital for women. She worked alongside her sister, Dr. Emily Blackwell. The two sisters also trained nurses for Union hospitals during the Civil War.

In 1868, Dr. Elizabeth Blackwell opened a medical college in New York City. A year later, she returned to her favorite place, England. She worked as a professor and published several books. Dr. Elizabeth Blackwell displayed great courage throughout her life, supporting the notion of women in medicine. She passed away in 1910 at the age of 89.

Both Clara Barton and Dr. Elizabeth Blackwell were indeed heroines of their time. Despite their different lives, they had much in common. They both left a long-lasting legacy of kindness to humanity.

Long-Distance Hiking

Chances are, you have enjoyed an afternoon of hiking. It's fun to spend a few hours exploring outside before heading home. But have you ever thought about spending days, weeks, or even months on a hiking trail? If you've decided to do some long-distance hiking, the Appalachian Trail, or A.T., could be the right challenge for you.

The A.T. starts in Georgia and ends in Maine. It is 2,200 miles long. Some people hike the trail in sections and go about 200 to 400 miles each summer, completing the trail over several years. However, hiking the entire trail at one time is quite common. This muscle testing experience can take about five months.

The A.T. was built with long-distance hikers in mind. There are several shelters all along the trail.

These shelters are between 5 and 15 miles apart, so it is important to plan your trip. The free shelters are open on a “first come, first served” basis. Although they are made to hold eight people, on a rainy night you will find considerably more people gathered under the shelter.

The A.T. also crosses many small towns. These towns have provided the hikers with places to purchase food, hotel rooms, and gear. Some of the towns are also recognized for their “Trail Magic.” Trail Magic is when townspeople leave hikers home-baked treats in the middle of the night.

If you are looking for an exciting and challenging new hike, consider trying the Appalachian Trail.

Modern Scarecrows

Whether the brain given to the Scarecrow in *The Wizard of Oz* made him smarter is debatable. But the robotic scarecrows in fields today are definitely smarter than the straw versions of the past.

Keeping pests and disease from destroying crops and animals has always been a problem for farmers. Finding unwanted wild animals huddled inside farm machinery can also be an issue. But with advances in robotics, motion detectors, and drones, farmers can now purchase devices that keep pests at bay. Motion-driven sprinklers throw out a burst of water, driving many animals away. A solar-powered robot with flashing eyes is used to scare large mammals such as deer. The robot can also howl in a variety of ways. This keeps animals from getting used to the sound.

Some devices make use of a bird's built-in fear response. When they hear distress calls from other birds, they panic. GPS-guided drones can remotely fly over a vast area of land. The drone's blades produce a loud hum while a megaphone blasts bird distress calls. This causes birds to fly away and avoid the area.

By the end of *The Wizard of Oz*, the Scarecrow is recognized as “the wisest man in all of Oz.” Today's smart scarecrows are saving countless crops by scaring off would-be predators while they roam the sky.

Rosa Parks Remains Seated PART ONE

Rosa Parks was born in Tuskegee, Alabama, at a time when segregation laws required Black people to use different restrooms, water fountains, buses, doors to buildings, and even schools. White people and Black people did not stand shoulder to shoulder anywhere.

Rosa left school when she was eleven to care for her grandmother and mother. At the urging of her husband, she completed school when she was twenty. As an adult, she became an activist and freedom fighter.

Rosa had to ride a segregated bus to work every day. This meant that she rode on a bus that had a section in the front for White people and a section in the back for Black people. On December 1, 1955, on her way home from work, she purchased a bus ticket

and sat in the first row available for Black people. After the bus became very crowded, White passengers were forced to stand. In response, the bus driver moved the placard saying “Whites Only” to the section behind where Rosa was seated. Then he told Rosa to get up and move further back. Rosa refused.

Many people have said that Rosa refused to give up her seat because she was old or just too tired. Rosa responded that she was not old and said, “The only tired I was, was tired of giving in.”

The bus driver told Rosa that if she did not move, he would call the police. She said, “You may go ahead and do so.” In the end she was taken to jail and fined.

Rosa Parks Remains Seated PART TWO

The city of Montgomery quickly united around Rosa. Flyers were printed asking all African Americans to refrain from using the city buses the following Monday. Masses of people became involved in the one-day boycott which was led by a young Martin Luther King. The boycott meant that all Black people would be walking to work, taking a cab, or carpooling that day. No one would purchase a ticket for the bus. The since named Montgomery Bus Boycott lasted 381 days.

The boycott led to the downfall of the public transportation system in Montgomery. As a result, lawmakers were forced to end segregation in the city's transportation system. Because of her time in

custody, Rosa lost her job as a seamstress in a nearby department store. Soon after that, death threats began making their way to her and her family. The Parks decided to move to Detroit where other family members lived. After moving, she ended up becoming the administrative assistant to a member of Congress - a position she held for many years.

Rosa Parks is often called the First Lady of Civil Rights as well as the Mother of the Freedom Movement. In 1999, Time Magazine named her as one of the Twenty-Five Most Powerful Women of the Age.

Rosa Parks was a model of courage and deep determination. She was one of the inspiring forces behind a movement that transformed our nation.

Open-Water Swimming

When most of us think of competitive swimming, we envision a 50-meter pool with lane lines and lifeguards. We do not think of dipping into salt water with no clear path. However, some people like a bit more of a challenge with their swimming, and they enjoy open-water swimming or long-distance swimming.

While no large body of water is barred, swimmers must swim a minimum of ten kilometers. Unlike the calm pool water, an open swim may be jarring. When the race begins, you may spend some time rubbing up against other swimmers in a free-for-all. As the race progresses, swimmers begin scattering. Because there are no lane lines, planning your path is necessary. Swimmers are always watching the horizon to make sure

they are moving in the right direction. With no walls to hang on to, there is no quitting in open water swimming!

Some of the most sought out swimming events are those that make up the Triple Crown of Open-Water Swimming. The Triple Crown consists of three swims. The most well-known swim is 21 miles across the foggy English Channel. The next is in sunny California, from the mainland to Catalina Island. This is about 26 miles. The last swim is the biggest, spanning the open waters around Manhattan Island.

If you find yourself up for a new challenge, you could try grabbing your wetsuit and diving into the open waters for a new swimming experience.

The Impact of the Great Depression

When the 1929 crash of the stock market stirred the Great Depression, people played down the consequences. Even President Herbert Hoover described it as “a passing incident.” Yeah, he thought things would return to normal after a couple of months. Nothing could have been further from the truth.

Banks flopped, farms crumbled, and shoppers found stores shutting their doors left and right. Before long, 15 million Americans were unemployed. People thought that working hard and not quitting was the way to success. Therefore, they often felt embarrassed to accept assistance. This resulted in severe widespread poverty even with women and children entering the labor force to help their families survive.

As the country’s problems expanded, a wealthy governor from New York stepped up. He ran for

President and was elected in 1932. His name was Franklin Delano Roosevelt. He penned a way out of the depression. It was fittingly called the New Deal. Roosevelt's winning plan involved first saving the banking industry. Then came expanding the role of the government to help guard against poverty and hopelessness.

The Great Depression lasted into the early 1940s. Its impact reached beyond America's borders - spinning into the economics of places such as Germany and Brazil. The day-to-day struggles caused many people to change the way they approached their finances forever. Some people guarded their earnings closely. Others were driven to set up a calm and happy life for themselves. Either way, the impacts of this historical event were scarring and long-lasting.

Words Have Power

In her youth, Toni Morrison heard her grandfather bragging about having read the Bible when it was illegal for him to do so. When he was growing up, reading was banned for Black men and women. Hearing a grandparent speak passionately about this helped Toni understand that “words have power.”

Toni Morrison was a witty and talented writer who penned many novels about modern and past experiences of Black people. Although sometimes snubbed in her early career because of her depiction of challenging topics, it wasn’t long before Toni nabbed accolades for her gripping and impassioned novels. Most notably winning a Nobel Prize in 1993 and snagging the Medal of Freedom in 2012.

Toni Morrison is often praised as a trailblazer for Black female writers. During the peak of her career,

Toni was getting some mixed responses from the public. While some people were brimming with flattery for the talented writer, others began nagging her about the subject matter of her novels. She remained calm as prodding questions flew her way about why she would write just about the Black experience. She could have shrugged off these questions but instead used them for spurring important discussions. It wasn't *just* anything she was writing about—these were some of the most important untold stories in American history.

Toni Morrison held a pen in her palm and jotted down the Black American experience, changing the novel forever. Her stunning depictions and eloquent prose opened up a whole new world of writing, and opened up many hearts as well.

Skin Cancer Prevention

Did you know that skin cancer is the most common cancer in the United States today? Whether you are jogging, trekking, swimming, or sitting on the beach, spending long hours in the sun may be putting you at risk. Most skin cancers are caused by ultraviolet (UV) rays. Usually, these rays come from the sun, but some may come from man-made sources such as tanning beds. The good news is there are many things you can do to help guard against the onset of skin cancer.

First, you should consider stepping up your skincare by using sunscreen. Experts recommend dabbing sunscreen on all exposed skin every day. Several layers are more effective than one, so don't hold back when dripping sunscreen into the palm of

your hand. Try plopping a bottle next to your phone to ensure you don't go anywhere without it.

Second, wear clothing that blocks the UV rays. Loose-fitting clothing made of dark, tightly woven fabric helps block sunlight while keeping you cool. Wear a wide-brimmed hat and sunglasses. If your sunglasses don't block UV rays, consider purchasing some that do, and encourage your parents to do the same.

Finally, try to stay in the shade and avoid direct sun between 10 AM and 4 PM, when the UV rays are strongest. You can enjoy being outside while also protecting your skin using these sun safety tips. Protecting the health of your skin rests firmly on your shoulders.

Blame The Dust Bowl PART ONE

Sometimes called the Black Blizzard, the Dust Bowl was a period of time when severe dust storms swept across the Great Plains of America. The unforgettable storms began in the early 1930s. They brought strong winds and thick dust across parts of Colorado, Kansas, Texas, Oklahoma, and New Mexico.

The reoccurring storms in the Great Plains were extremely destructive. Because of this, an estimated 35 million acres of farmland had been destroyed by 1934. Another 125 million acres of land had lost its top layer of soil - the part of the soil that is necessary for planting crops. As a result, animals and crops failed across the entire region.

At times, the effects of the unpredictable storms even reached the east coast of America and beyond. In

1934, a gigantic and unstoppable dust storm traveled 2,000 miles. As a result, it dropped a blanket of dust across New York City and Washington, D.C. The storm dumped powdery dust on everything. It even got inside homes through the smallest of cracks. As the dust spread to the Atlantic Ocean, it left crews on ships wondering why they were coated in dust.

The worst storm happened on April 14, 1935. Starting in Oklahoma, cold air and strong winds whipped up a dust cloud that grew to hundreds of miles wide and thousands of feet high. As panicked people listened to the wind and fastened their eyes to the sky, they knew they had to run for cover. By the time the sky cleared, the storm transferred an estimated three million tons of soil. It's no wonder that news reporters fittingly referred to this horrific day as Black Sunday.

Blame The Dust Bowl PART TWO

It took great American spirit to survive the terrible Dust Bowl years. With dust floating in the air and covering the land, it's no wonder that people's health suffered. Many victims experienced chest pain and had difficulty breathing. Due to severe illness in their lungs, some people never recovered. As upsetting as it is to think about, we don't actually know for certain how many people passed away.

Population levels decreased. However, the number one cause of the rapidly declining population was not deaths. It was a result of families preferring to leave the area to seek work and a better life. In fact, over two million people left the Dust Bowl states in the 1930s. This resulted in one of the largest migrations in the history of America. Oklahoma alone lost over 400,000 people to migration, many of whom transferred their lives to California.

The economic effects of the storms were compounded by the Great Depression and lasted for dozens of years. Consequently, the President of the United States, Franklin D. Roosevelt listened. He took steps to help the people directly impacted by the storms, especially farmers. In addition, Congress admitted that the country needed help. They conferred and established programs to put local farmers to work and develop ways to stop soil erosion.

Windbreaks, also called shelterbreaks, were planted to protect soil and crops from dry winds and prevent soil erosion. Windbreaks are strips of large shrubs, trees, or tall crops that act as a kind of wall. Because of these government efforts, most of the plains were restored by the early 1940s.

Globetrotting to Iceland

If you consider yourself a globetrotter, you may have visited dozens of places around the world. But have you ever been compelled to visit Iceland? Iceland is a European country in the North Atlantic Ocean. In recent years, Iceland has committed to becoming a travel destination for Americans by offering more affordable flights between Iceland and the United States. Admittedly, many Americans use Iceland as a stepping-stone to get to mainland Europe. Those American travelers who don't spend any time in Iceland may find themselves regretting their decision.

With a little preplanning, you can see Iceland's amazing volcanic black sand beaches. The strong tides of the Atlantic Ocean have carved out arches

from the cliffside. There is also a large outcropping of pillars several meters offshore. According to legend, these huge pillars were once young trolls who rebelled against their parents and stayed out after sunrise. Since trolls are forbidden to see the sun, they were transformed into stone.

Day-trippers may be wondering how best to spend a limited amount of time. An unplanned afternoon walking through a glacier and swimming in one of the many hot springs could be a good way to unwind. If your preferred trip involves more city spirit, the capital offers a large selection of restaurants.

Whatever your interests, committing to a trip to Iceland could be an unforgettable experience.

Sugar Temptation

Jasper and Rowan were feeling downtrodden after their visit to the doctor's office. Their blood sugar was raised because they both submitted to temptation and ate sweet treats instead of healthy foods. Admittedly, it never occurred to them that their eating habits could lead to such upsetting health consequences.

They decided to meet with a fitness trainer. She formatted a meal plan with limited amounts of sugar, preferring fruit over candy. She compelled them to give up their sweetened coffee. They were permitted only one sweet treat per week. Jasper did wonder if their trainer was overstepping, but Rowan said they needed to listen to her suggestions. Jasper and Rowan deferred to their trainer's advice and set up a

healthy new diet. They omitted most sweets and even developed a new exercise plan.

These changes propelled Jasper and Rowan to better health. At first it was upsetting to give up the dozens of sweets that they enjoyed, but when their blood sugar decreased they stopped regretting all their sacrifices. Jasper and Rowan were fully committed to their new, healthy life.

Megan's Robot PART ONE

Megan came from a very athletic family. However, sports just did not interest her, so she was looking for an alternative use of her time. One day, she saw a flyer posted in the school lunchroom. It was an invitation to come hear about the school's robotics club. Megan snapped a photo on her cellphone and entered the date and time in her calendar app.

A few days later, Megan entered the room where the robotics club meeting was held. She was pleasantly surprised to find that there was a lot of interest in the club. The club's president, Roger, began with some introductions and a definition of the word robotics. Megan learned that robotics is the design, construction, and use of machines to perform tasks—tasks usually done by humans.

Next, Roger explained that the school's robotics club was a group of students who were interested in learning about and experimenting with robots. The club met after school twice a week and Mrs. Sanderson, the school's engineering teacher, was the staff leader. Most importantly, Megan learned that it was not necessary to have an expertise in robotics before joining the club. The members all start out as beginners.

Roger ended his talk by sharing photos of some of the club's projects over the last two years. Megan was immensely impressed with what she saw, and she knew this was an opportunity to put her excellent science and math skills to work. When Roger passed around a sign-up sheet at the end of the meeting, Megan eagerly added her name.

Megan's Robot PART TWO

Megan attended the robotics club meetings twice a week. She made new friends and enjoyed learning from the more experienced members. It was not about perfectionism. The club focused on imagination, teamwork, and fun.

Each year, the club participated in robotics competitions - local, state, and national. During her first year, Megan prepared for a local competition. She was tasked with building a robot that could perform an everyday task. Megan learned about how to construct a robot. A good robot needs a body or robot frame, sensors that detect things in its environment, and a “brain” or processing unit. In addition, robots need motors or moving parts and a power source.

Megan also had to learn how to develop a code for her robot. The coding for a robot is like instructions

that a robot or computer program can read and perform. There is a lot of experimenting with this process, altering the design and the code many times. Megan loved the challenges.

After several months, Megan had her first robot working. The everyday task it performed was to make a sandwich. Her robot, which she named Harvey, could pick up a slice of bread, put a slice of meat on it, and then cover the meat with another slice of bread.

On the day of the local robotics competition, Megan confidently showed off her lunch-making robot, Harvey. The rest of the robotics club was in attendance observantly cheering Megan on each step of the way. Megan placed third. It was just the beginning of her visionary work and expertise with robotics.

What Caused the Great Depression? PART ONE

Beginning in 1929 and lasting until 1939, the Great Depression had a worldwide impact. It was, in fact, the worst economic depression ever experienced. So why did it happen?

This question and related hypotheses have been examined for many years. Researchers with expertise in history and economics have sensibly outlined several important factors that contributed to the unprecedented and persistent Great Depression.

Let's start with the "Roaring 20s." As the name suggests, life was good! However, the U.S. government set forth one experimental policy after another. Most of which inflated the idealistic perception about how good things really were. This encouraged investors to embark on new enterprises. The emergence of this

temporary influx of money gave rise to an economic boom. Prices began to rise until business was no longer profitable.

It doesn't take someone with economic expertise to tell you that when profits go away, a downward shift begins—and that's just what happened. Admirably, emergency adjustments to interest rates were made and the banks started lending out more money.

However, these alternative circumstances caused the majority of U.S. residents to make false assumptions about the economy.

After years of boom and bust cycles, profits fell. As a consequence, the stock market crashed on October 24th in 1929. This famed day is also called Black Thursday.

What Caused the Great Depression? PART TWO

President Herbert Hoover set forth actions to intervene with the economic hard times. However, his visionary ideas took a severe recession and turned it into a turbulent depression. One example of this was the passing of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff in 1930. This law intended to boost prices in the American economy. The goal was to keep products from other nations out. With the borders closed to foreign goods, a succession of catastrophic consequences played out. These included the disappearance of trade lines, staggering unemployment, and declining farm prices. Accessibility to international commerce was vital to America's fiscal well-being. Apparently, Hoover and Congress ignored this core principle.

In 1932, Franklin Delano Roosevelt was elected to office. There was great hope for his alternative “New Deal.” Most of the components of this legendary administration’s experiment were focused on repairing depression-related conditions. However, he also hoped to stimulate the economy. FDR confidently and urgently instituted the minimum wage. He banned youth labor. His intentions focused on the nation’s recovery. It all sounds good, but the truth is that Roosevelt is often credited as being responsible for the severity of the Great Depression. There was an abundance of taxes, codes, and regulations—but no deducible results!

It wasn’t until the start of World War II and a new administration in office that things started to turn around for America.

New Treatments for Hearing Loss

The promise of hearing restoration to people who have lost some of this sense may be on the horizon. The delicate cells that enable us to hear are called hair cells. These cells do not repair themselves when a loud noise leads to damage. Nor do they come back when we see a decrease in these cells during the regular aging process. With each hair cell lost, we lose some of our hearing.

Communication can be a challenge among those affected by hearing loss. When communication is inadequate, it can result in feelings of isolation. Scientists are hopeful that new medicines to treat hearing loss may be on the way.

Scientists are working on a way to replace the delicate sound-detecting hair cells in the inner ear. They've even pinpointed new molecules that help them to increase the number of hair cells. These lab-grown cells

can then be used to test medicines for hearing loss in living cells.

Ultimately, the best solution to most problems is routine prevention. Manage hearing loss by taking advantage of inexpensive earplugs that you can carry with you everywhere. Use them at loud concerts and around machinery. Encourage your friends to buy some too. Don't deliberately turn up the volume when listening to music with earbuds. You may not notice the damage fast enough to stop it. Earbuds without volume control can deliver enough sound to damage your ears in just fifteen minutes!

There is some good news. For people who suffer from unavoidable hearing loss, new medicines to replace hair cells with damage may be on the way.

Good Garden Management

Have you ever had a garden in your backyard? Perhaps you have participated in a cooperative garden nearby. Growing food is of interest to people all around the world. Some say it is hard to imagine anything better than planting a tiny seed that grows into food to eat. If gardening is a popular activity amongst your family, take advantage of the following facts to make your routine harvest even better!

To begin, no complicated machinery is needed. Just examine your yard. Choose a location with lots of sun and adequate access to water. Good soil is also a must. Your soil should be fertile but practical. Harsh substances found in some manmade products can harm your yard's surface. This can also eliminate

helpful insects living there. To avoid these negative consequences, try making your own fertile soil!

How do you make fertile soil for your garden? Just toss leftover food and other household waste, like lawnmower clippings and leaves, into a pile in the corner of your yard. If you are determined and willing to wait, these items will decompose over time, providing you with rich compost.

Now you may plant your preselected seeds. Separate delicate plants with a fence. Examine your plants for unexpected damage. Be sure to remove all unwanted bugs and other critters to encourage growth. Soon you will have no shortage of fresh food at your table!

What's Up with All this Dust? PART ONE

The Dust Bowl of the 1930s had terrible consequences to the Great Plains of America, including deaths and an epic migration. This begs us to examine the question, “What caused the dust storms in the first place?”

It's important to look back in time to answer this question. After the Civil War, a variety of government land grants convinced settlers to head westward and populate the Great Plains. As a consequence, countless unskilled farmers took to the land. Amongst the settlers were many folks who were convinced of the logic that “rain follows the plow.” They were sure that by deliberately farming the fragile land, the climate would adjust in their favor.

Before 1870, the desolate area known as the Great Plains was actually called the “Great American Desert.” This was due to its dry weather and arid land. Growing crops in this hostile environment was nearly impossible. However, by the end of the 19th century, rain began to be a routine event in this area. This newly wet climate was celebrated. It continued through the 1920s producing more and more fertile land. This strengthened the notion that farming the land would salvage the area’s ecology.

What's Up with All this Dust? PART TWO

As a result of the apparent climate change, another round of migrants decided to relocate their lives during World War I. They took route to the Great Plains also in hopes of farming the land. There was an increased demand for wheat during the war. This motivated farmers to vacate millions of acres of native grass. Advances in farming equipment made this job less difficult. Large areas of land could be plowed in much less time. However, this meant that the native grass that usually trapped moist soil, even during times of dry weather, was no longer there.

Contrary to 19th century thinking that “the rain follows the plow,” the wet climate that provided so much hope was indeed temporary. By the 1930s, the rain had stopped!

Because of all the modern farming methods, the native grass had been replaced with acres and acres of crops. When the routinely dry weather returned, the damaged topsoil, or upper layer of soil, would graduate to dry dirt. Ultimately, the dry dirt turned to dust!

This dust was effortlessly picked up by the strong winds of the Great Plains. The result was massive dust storms. Some were so big that they would last for days and even block out the sun.

History inevitably revealed that all of these economic and agricultural factors caused the dust storms of the 1930s.